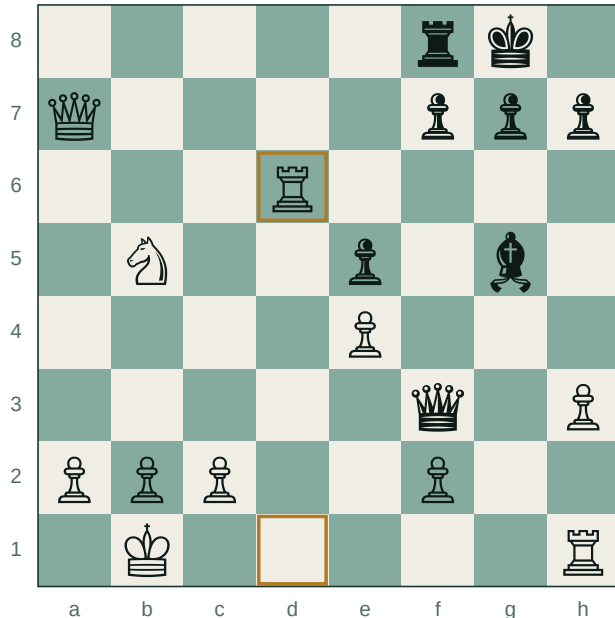


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 20

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 20.Rxd6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20...Qxh1+ 21. Rd1 Qxd1#

20...Qxh1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the rook on h1. Recorded reply: **21.Rd1**.

21...Qxd1# Mate: queen on d1 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on b1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on d1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on b1. Geometrically undefended: knight on b5 and rook on h1. Check for tactical protection.